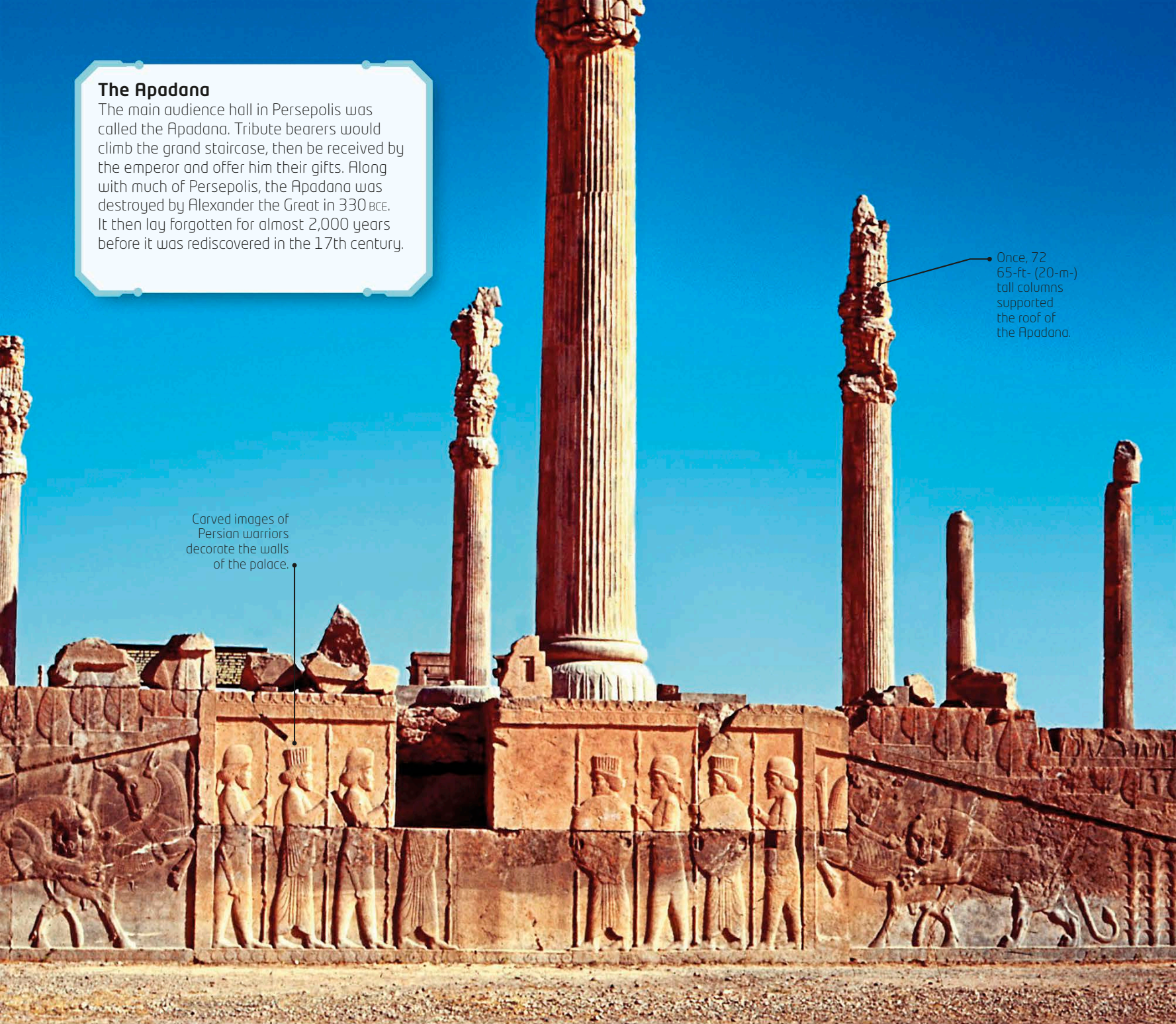


The Apadana

The main audience hall in Persepolis was called the Apadana. Tribute bearers would climb the grand staircase, then be received by the emperor and offer him their gifts. Along with much of Persepolis, the Apadana was destroyed by Alexander the Great in 330 BCE. It then lay forgotten for almost 2,000 years before it was rediscovered in the 17th century.

Carved images of Persian warriors decorate the walls of the palace.

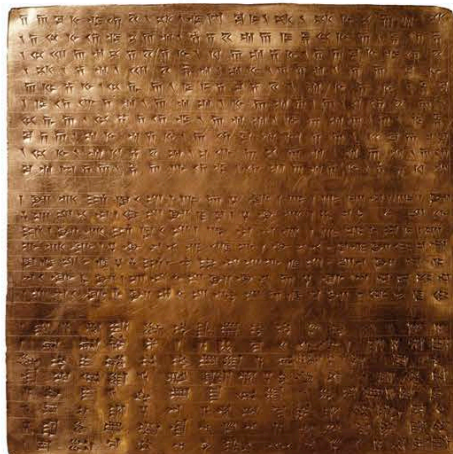
Once, 72 65-ft- (20-m-) tall columns supported the roof of the Apadana.



Foundations

Two golden tablets were found buried under the foundations of the Apadana.

The writing on them outlines the territories of the Persian Empire and thanks the Persian god Ahura Mazda in three different languages.



AHURA MAZDA



The Persians followed the Zoroastrian religion. They believed in a god called Ahura Mazda—"wise lord." This carving from Persepolis shows Ahura Mazda as a man rising up from a winged disk.